

INLAND

Tunisia

A Mediterranean Edition · Overview

12 SELECTED STORIES · INSTITUT FRANÇAIS — MEDITERRANEAN PHOTOGRAPHY
SUPPORT · 2026

Tunisia is internationally legible through three loud stories — the 2011 revolution that began the Arab Spring, the Mediterranean migration crossings that leave from Sfax and Zarzis, and the beach-resort coast. All three are loud; all three crowd out the quieter country. INLAND asks one question across every lead: what survived? What persists on the shore and the islands that has been absorbed by neither the Phoenician–Roman antiquity the tour buses visit, the French protectorate, the resort economy, nor the post-revolution turbulence — and can still be witnessed and photographed today.

We read Tunisia as a Mediterranean palimpsest — Phoenician, Roman, Amazigh, Andalusian, Jewish, Ibadi, sub-Saharan and Ottoman — through the people who keep its endangered knowledge: the palm-frond charfia fences of Kerkennah, the hand-built pottery of the women of Sejnane, the Stambeli trance liturgy of Black Tunisia. The sea is crossing, frontier, larder and memory. The revolution and the migration crisis are context, never the lens; the state is never cast as villain.

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The 12 Storylines

The Palm in the Sea

The Charfia of the Kerkennah Islands
THE STORY

On the low, palm-fringed Kerkennah Islands off Sfax, fishermen still plant date-palm fronds in rows across the shallows to build the charfia — a great V of woven palm that channels fish on the ebb tide into capture chambers, the grounds shared by a draw of lots and worked to a maritime calendar. UNESCO inscribed it in 2020.

“A fence of palm leaves, planted in the sea, older than any net.”

Places: Kerkennah Islands · Sfax · Sources: UNESCO ICH 2020 (Charfia fishing); Earth Journalism Network; New Arab

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one charfia family through the autumn setting of the fronds and a dawn lift of the traps — a fishing architecture built entirely from the palm, standing in the Mediterranean. The edition's signature recurring image.

The Women Who Build with Earth

Sejnane's Amazigh Potters
THE STORY

In the Mogods hills behind Bizerte, the women of Sejnane hand-build pots, animals and the famous Sejnane dolls from wadi clay with no wheel and no kiln, firing them in open ground and painting them with two-tone geometric signs from tattoo and Berber weaving — a craft passed mother to daughter for some three thousand years.

“No wheel, no kiln — only the hand, the fire, and three thousand years.”

Places: Sejnane · Mogods · Bizerte · Sources: UNESCO ICH 2018 (Pottery of the women of Sejnane); The Arab Weekly; phys.org

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND portraits one named potter through a full cycle — digging and kneading the clay, shaping by hand, the open firing, the painting — a Mediterranean ceramics tradition that predates the wheel and belongs entirely to women. UNESCO-inscribed 2018.

The Island of Three Prayers

Djerba's Ibadis & El Ghriba
THE STORY

On Djerba, Ibadi Muslims built low, fortified, sometimes half-underground mosques across an island of menzel farmsteads and rain-cisterns, while at El Ghriba — held to be Africa's oldest synagogue — Jewish pilgrims still gather each spring for the Lag BaOmer procession. UNESCO listed the whole island in 2023.

“Three kinds of mosque, a church and a synagogue, on one waterless island.”

Places: Djerba · Hara Kebira · Erriadh · Sources: UNESCO WHC 2023 (Djerba); El Ghriba (Wikipedia); The Arab Weekly

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND works the island as one fabric — a fortified Ibadi mosque at prayer, a menzel courtyard, the El Ghriba pilgrimage — documenting the only place in the Arab world where Ibadi, Maliki, Hanafi, Christian and Jewish communities have shared a small island for centuries.

The Villages That Speak the Old Tongue

The Amazigh Ksour of the Dahar
THE STORY

On the ridges of the Dahar above Tataouine, the Amazigh villages of Chenini and Douiret cling to the rock around honeycombed ghorfa granaries and a white mosque, and a dwindling number of elders still speak Tamazight where a generation ago far more did. Below, families have moved to ‘new’ villages with roads and water.

“A language kept like seed-grain, in a granary on a hill.”

Places: Chenini · Douiret · Tataouine · Sources: Carthage Magazine (Amazigh heritage); WildyNess; Discover Tunisia

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows a family that still keeps a hill house and a ghorfa — the olive-and-barley year, the granary, the Tamazight spoken at home — documenting one of the last living Berber-speaking pockets of a country that mostly forgot it was Amazigh.

The Clock That Runs Backward

Testour’s Andalusians & the Malouf
THE STORY

Testour, in the Medjerda valley, was rebuilt in the 17th century by Moriscos expelled from Spain; its Great Mosque carries a clock whose hands turn counter-clockwise — read locally as the exiles’ longing to wind time back toward Andalusia — and the town keeps the malouf, the Arab-Andalusian music carried across the sea.

“They set the clock to run home, across a sea they could not recross.”

Places: Testour · Medjerda · Béja · Sources: The Arab Weekly; The National; Tunisian malouf (Wikipedia)

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND spends the malouf festival with a family of Testour musicians and follows the Andalusian thread through the town — the backward clock, the brick mosque, the pomegranate orchards — a four-century-old Mediterranean exile still audible.

The Oasis by the Sea

Gabès, the Last Maritime Oasis
THE STORY

Gabès holds the Mediterranean’s only seaside oasis — a three-tier garden of date palm, pomegranate, henna and vegetable running down to the shore, watered for millennia — now poisoned at its edge by the state phosphate works that have piled phosphogypsum into the gulf for fifty years. Farmers describe henna and pomegranate failing.

“A garden that has met the sea for three thousand years, now meeting the factory.”

Places: Gabès · Chenini Gabès · Gulf of Gabès · Sources: Med-O-Med (Gabès oasis); Coda Story; TIMEP; SEVENSEAS

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND documents the oasis from inside — a henna grower, the layered garden, the old irrigation — against the chimneys at its margin: a living agricultural landscape and the industry pressing on it. Tension, not indictment; the gardeners are the subject.

The Spirits Carried North

Stambeli, Black Tunisia's Healing Trance

THE STORY

In a few houses in Tunis — above all Dar Barnou, once a refuge for freed slaves — the descendants of sub-Saharan people brought across the Sahara keep Stambeli, a night music of the gambri lute and iron shqasheq that calls a pantheon of sub-Saharan spirits and Muslim saints to heal through trance. It survives in a handful of brotherhoods.

“The drum crossed the desert in chains, and it is still healing.”

Places: Tunis · Dar Barnou · Sidi Saad · Sources: Stambeli (Wikipedia); Jankowsky, Stambeli (U. Chicago); Pan-African Music

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND sits a full Stambeli night with one of the last troupes — the tuning, the incense, the colours each spirit demands, the dance — documenting Black Tunisia's living liturgy with consent, as ritual rather than spectacle.

FOOD

The Last Matanza

The Bluefin Trap of Cap Bon

THE STORY

At Sidi Daoud, on the tip of Cap Bon, fishermen set the madrague — a labyrinth of nets the locals call the matanza — to trap migrating Atlantic bluefin between May and July, a Phoenician-old technique that ends in a churning chamber of tuna hauled by hand. Quotas, industrial fleets and warming water have all but stilled it.

“A maze of nets the Phoenicians would recognise, sprung once a year.”

Places: Sidi Daoud · Cap Bon · El Haouaria · Sources: INSTM Bulletin (madrague Sidi Daoud); Mattanza (Wikipedia); harissa.com

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND embeds for a season at one of the Mediterranean's last working tuna traps — the building of the net-rooms, the watch for the school, the matanza itself — a violent, ancient sea-harvest at the edge of disappearing.

FOOD

White Gold

Distilling Neroli at Nabeul

THE STORY

Each April and May around Nabeul, families pick the bitter-orange blossom by hand before dawn, when the scent is strongest, and distil it over slow fire in copper alembics into zhar — orange-blossom water for sweets and grief and celebration — and the precious neroli oil. A million flowers make a kilogram of oil.

“For two weeks the whole coast smells of one flower.”

Places: Nabeul · Hammamet · Cap Bon · Sources: Africanews (Nabeul orange blossom); Middle East Eye; Biolandes

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows one family's blossom week — the pre-dawn picking, the qattara still, the bottling — a Mediterranean perfume-and-kitchen tradition where the whole coast smells of one tree for a fortnight a year.

The Gold-Threaded Loom

Wedding Silk of Mahdia
THE STORY

In the sea-walled medina of Mahdia, weavers still work tall draw-looms — a technology that came across the Mediterranean from Iberia — to make narrow silk strips threaded with gold and silver for the keswa el-kbira, the layered wedding dress that tells a Sahel woman's married status. The craft was brought by Jewish artisans.

“A marriage you can read in the gold of the cloth.”

Places: Mahdia · the Sahel coast · Sources: Carthage Magazine (Tunisian wedding); Discover Tunisia; shirahime.ch

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND portraits a master weaver and a bride's family through the making and wearing of a gold-silk keswa — the loom, the shuttle, the dressing — a coastal textile tradition where a wedding is still woven by hand.

HISTORY

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The Knot and the Sweet

The Holy City's Carpets
THE STORY

Kairouan, Islam's fourth holy city and its first in Africa, is also Tunisia's carpet capital, where women knot the zerbia — hundreds of thousands of knots a square metre — in workshops around the Great Mosque, and bake the date-and-semolina makroud the city claims as its own. Both loom and oven are pressed by cheaper imports.

“Half a million knots, said like a prayer, in the city of the first mosque.”

Places: Kairouan · the Medina · Sources: Discover Tunisia (weaving & carpets); Folk Culture (Kairouan carpet); WildyNess

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND works the medina with one weaving family and one makroud house — the dyed wool, the knotting frame, the honeyed pastry — documenting the holy city through the women's hands that keep its two famous crafts.

LOCAL COMMUNITIES

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The Green Mountain

Cork Oak and the Khroumir
THE STORY

In the Kroumirie range above Tabarka, where it snows in winter and the cork-oak forest is unlike anywhere else in Tunisia, the Khroumir mountain people harvest cork on its long bark-cycle, herd and gather among the trees, and keep a green, wet, half-forgotten north that contradicts the country's Saharan image.

“A Tunisia of oak bark and snow, where you expected only sand.”

Places: Aïn Draham · Kroumirie · Tabarka · Sources: Carthage Magazine (Aïn Draham); Tunisi.info (Kroumirie); Take Your Backpack

OUR PROPOSAL

INLAND follows a cork-harvesting family through a summer stripping season and the forest year — the orange-stripped trunks, the herding, the highland village — documenting the Mediterranean Tunisia of oak and rain rather than palm and dune.

Production Tracks

The South & the Islands

STORIES 01 + 03 + 04 + 06

The Mediterranean south: the charfia palm-fences of Kerkennah, the coexistence-island of Djerba (Ibadi mosques + El Ghriba), the Amazigh ksour of the Dahar, and the threatened seaside oasis of Gabès. One southern deployment.

Geography: Kerkennah/Sfax → Gabès → Djerba → Tataouine
Season: Charfia autumn-set; El Ghriba pilgrimage (spring)
4 stories, 1 southern base

Cap Bon & the Sahel

STORIES 08 + 09 + 10 + 11

The eastern shoulder: the Sidi Daoud bluefin matanza and the Nabeul orange-blossom stills of Cap Bon, the wedding silk of Mahdia and the carpets and makroudh of holy Kairouan. Sea and craft on the Sahel.

Geography: Cap Bon (Sidi Daoud/ Nabeul) → Kairouan → Mahdia
Season: Blossom Apr–May; matanza May–Jul
4 stories, spring window

The Green North

STORIES 02 + 05 + 07 + 12

The wet, layered north: the women potters of Sejnane, the Andalusian malouf of Testour, the Stambeli brotherhoods of Tunis, and the Kroumirie cork-oak country above Tabarka. The Tunisia of oak, exile and rain.

Geography: Tunis → Testour (Medjerda) → Sejnane (Bizerte) → Ain Draham
Season: Cork stripping & malouf festival (summer)
4 stories, 1 northern loop

Two Strands, One Edition

THE PUBLICATION

INLAND — yearly publication (Italy / EU). A finished Tunisia edition (~170–240 pp) on the Mediterranean theme, in the register of Issue 03, Isole Minori. The Institut français publication aid covers editing and printing in full.

THE PRODUCTION

The field shoot across three coastal-and-island clusters — Kerkennah, Cap Bon–Sahel, the green north — funded by the production strand for new Mediterranean photographic work.

WHY THE MEDITERRANEAN

Tunisia is a Mediterranean palimpsest — Phoenician, Roman, Amazigh, Andalusian, Jewish, Ibadi and sub-Saharan — read through living custodians on its shores and islands, exactly the ‘monde méditerranéen’ the programme funds.

THE PRINCIPLE

Named custodians, locatable places, seasonal scenes — made with the people who keep these traditions, not about them. The loud Tunisia of revolution and migration stays as context; the quieter country is the subject.